Reading Over the Machine's Shoulder

Flour-sack cinema and actuarial anticombinatorics after Calvino

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Abstract

A burnt copybook leaves twelve deeds and no reliable account of who committed them. *Abominable House* turns Italo Calvino's premise into a browser-native film bank in which four flour sacks enact alternative histories. Its state ledger separates a deed from the conditions under which a tenant can see it or discover its trace. Two experiments show what this separation buys. Exact enumeration reveals that plausible-sounding restrictions on a wrestler change the modeled exposure of an unrelated life-insurance claim. A lighting intervention changes who learns about two deeds while preserving their cast and order. Together they make procedural cinema a way to examine how formal constraints distribute both evidence and liability.

A burnt index and an interested reader

In Calvino's 1973 story, Waldemar is hired by an insurer to reconstruct a boarding-house fire. The surviving index gives neither the participants nor the sequence of the twelve deeds. The company has a stake in the reconstruction. Ogiva's child can claim on Widow Roessler's life policy unless it can be shown that Ogiva killed her. Later, Waldemar suspects that Skiller supplied noise alongside evidence so a second programmer could reconstruct the tenants' culpability while overlooking the insurer's (Calvino 1995). The mystery therefore concerns who gets to define admissible evidence as much as who did what.

Abominable House (Hartsoe 2026) makes that authority inspectable. I call its form *minimum viable video-text*, a playable film whose scenes are assembled from addressable performances and whose transitions can be inspected as changes in world state. Manovich (2001) treats database and narrative as distinct cultural forms. Here one address leads from a case in the Film Bank to its individual performances in the Deed Bank. The spectator can watch the sequence, pause at a deed in T ZERO, substitute a pair, and replay the consequences. The animation of a deed, its consequence, a tenant's memory, and the transition into the next deed are separate modules. The runtime composes them against the same ledger. A changed pair can therefore change the traces, body marks, and memories available to later scenes. This is what lets a single edit become an experiment in the continuity of a film.

What the sieve does to a policy

Calvino (2003) calls the computer's selection of realizations compatible with constraints *anticombinatorics*. Pierazzo (2025) similarly obtains a trillion-scale space by choosing which parts of manuscript witnesses to represent as variables. The Film Bank fixes a twelve-deed sequence and gives each slot twelve ordered pairs of distinct tenants. Its 8,916,100,448,256 addresses count assignments. The five filters in *Twelve to the Twelfth* retain 2,663,172,255,744 of them. A separate count based on the ledger's survival and restraint rules applies a different criterion.

I operationalized the life-policy exception as a binary test. A claim is payable unless Ogiva is assigned to knife or strangle Roessler. Each assignment receives equal weight within its regime, and the named acts serve as proxies for the killing alleged in the story. The payable share is 121/144 (84.03%) without restrictions. Preventing Belindo from knifing and from being strangled reduces each of the two slots to nine pairs, lowering the share to 64/81 (79.01%). Under all five filters it is 50/63 (79.37%). To reproduce that result, enumerate the twelve possible pairs in each of the seven slots the filters touch and multiply by 12^5 for the five free slots. The gun-and-restraint conditions and the slander conditions factor out of the payout ratio. The remaining filter forbids knifing and strangling the same recipient, leaving 63 joint assignments, of which 50 pay.

The largest shift follows from constraints that mention neither Ogiva nor Roessler. The smaller shift comes from coupling two deeds. Waldemar himself withdraws the shared-recipient prohibition when he imagines a stabbing staged after a strangulation (Calvino 1995). Keeping that rule in one regime and releasing it in another makes his revision measurable. The percentages describe an invented test of the fictional claim under specified assumptions. They express neither a historical actuarial rate nor a verdict about the house.

What the lamp lets a tenant know

The four tenants are color-coded flour sacks. Weight, posture, props, and sound carry the performances, while sexual violence is implied through occlusion and aftermath. The abstraction makes the pairings reusable and gives the production a way to stage consequences without depicting the assault itself. It also puts a limit on what a spectator can identify from a silhouette or prop. This is a practical instance of Krämer's (2023) flattening, where a reduced surface makes some relations easier to work with and others harder to see.

Knowles and Tenney's *The House of Dust* (1967) combines material, site, light, and inhabitants in computer-generated quatrains. In the Film Bank those terms enter the ledger. A deed leaves a trace, and illumination can determine who learns from it. This turns a methodological problem identified by Jokisch and Rojas Castro (2025) into a staging decision. Co-presence, direct witnessing, and later discovery can connect the same characters to different events.

I replayed deeds VIII and IX of film 1541585241617 at the published source revision (Hartsoe 2026). During IX, Inigo is present in the bedroom and learns of the current deed, while Roessler finds the curtain left by VIII. I reran the ledger with the bedroom dark only during IX. Inigo remained present and neither knowledge update occurred. The staged comparison shows the role of the threshold. It also exposes a shortcut. Finding the curtain grants access to the originating deed record, whose participants the engine can recover. The curtain alone gives a human investigator weaker grounds for attribution. An insurer who takes a recorded absence of witnesses as grounds to dismiss a claim would inherit assumptions about lighting and discovery. The artwork makes it possible to ask how these rules could interact, a question the two experiments leave open.

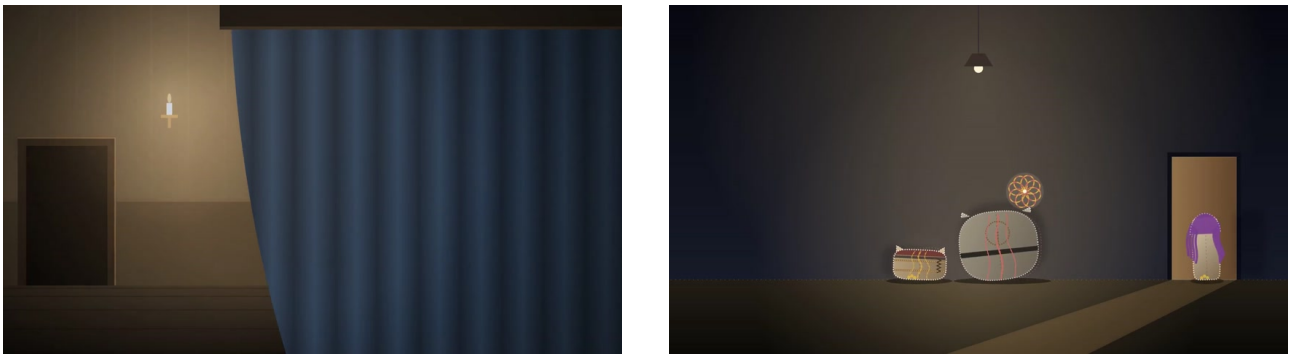


Figure 1. The curtain in deed VIII (left) and the lit bedroom in deed IX (right). Stills from film 1541585241617, director's cut, at 2:05.5 and 2:26.5. The darkness intervention was run in the ledger. Artwork by the author.

What the spectator can verify

Geertz (1973, 452) places interpretation over the shoulders of the people whose practices are being read. Here the metaphor points to authored decisions inside a machine. The spectator can follow a cut back to an assignment, a clue back to a transition, and a verdict back to an exclusion. The distinction matters for evaluation. The implemented watcher follows the cast sequence, drawing on inverse inverse planning (Chandra et al. 2024). The renderer can vary memories and consequence shots while leaving that sequence fixed, so its watcher curves cannot establish what viewers learn from a particular cut. The presentation will screen the curtain sequence and compare its two ledger traces alongside the policy calculation. A text summary will identify each change in knowledge without relying on color or sound. The creative contribution is a film that makes its own grounds for inference available for inspection and revision.

Artwork and replication

Open the project, the cited Film Bank case, or the published counts. Source revision 0ef3a04103f4. The case URL recovers the cast assignment. Figure 1 screening.

Generative AI disclosure

Generative AI assisted with code development and production review during the project, and with source discovery, drafting, and verification scripts for this submission. The reported counts and lighting test were checked against explicit rules and the cited JavaScript revision.

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